

Zeta Doradus
2 SunsGamma Doradus
7 Suns

DORADO

THE GOLDFISH

A CHAIN OF STARS NEAR THE BRILLIANT STAR CANOPUS IN CARINA, DORADO INCLUDES THE IMPRESSIVE LARGE MAGELLANIC CLOUD, A NEIGHBORING GALAXY OF THE MILKY WAY.

Although commonly described as a goldfish and sometimes depicted as a swordfish, Dorado represents the dolphinfish, a species found in tropical waters. Its shape is drawn around a faint chain of stars, with the fish swimming toward the south celestial pole. The constellation was introduced to the southern sky in the 1590s by the Dutch navigators Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman. It has no very bright stars, and none are named. Its most spectacular feature, the Large Magellanic Cloud (LMC), is visible to the naked eye but binoculars reveal its numerous star clusters and nebulous patches in more detail. The LMC is named after Ferdinand Magellan, the Portuguese explorer who recorded it in the early 1520s. The Tarantula Nebula is part of the LMC, and the Supernova 1987A was seen in the outskirts of this nebula in 1987.

The **Tarantula Nebula**, named for its spiderlike shape, is the only nebula **outside the Milky Way** visible with the **naked eye**

▷ Star distances

Dorado's closest pattern star to Earth and relatively nearby at just 38 light-years is Zeta (ζ) Doradus, a white main-sequence star. The most distant pattern star is the yellow supergiant Beta (β) Doradus, which is more than 26 times farther away, at 1,005 light-years from Earth.

